Nursing Styles

AI Voice Platform Comparison

Choosing the platform that will answer our after-hours calls, and what each option would cost and require

November 2026

Purpose

Our After Hours Call Workflow describes an AI voice agent that answers both office lines on weeknights from 5:00 PM to 9:00 AM, all weekend, and on agency holidays, with Centratel staying in place as the live operator backup. This document compares the platforms that could run that agent, so Shaun and the management team can choose one with a clear view of cost, privacy, and effort.

Every option was measured against what the workflow asks the platform to do:

- **Sign a HIPAA Business Associate Agreement (BAA)** before any real call is handled. No BAA, no go-live.
- **Look up AxisCare during the call** (read-only) to verify caregivers and read back upcoming visits, using the AxisCare REST API, and ideally write each finished call back to AxisCare as a call log or note.
- **Transfer callers to a person**: the agency's Centratel line on request, and on-call staff when needed.
- **Notify on-call staff** by phone call and secure message, working down the escalation ladder until someone acknowledges, with no PHI in plain texts.
- **Record and transcribe every call**, with the recording notice spoken first. Florida requires the consent of all parties to record a phone call (Florida Statutes 934.03).
- **Follow our own triage rules**: four urgency levels, 911 first for emergencies, no medical advice, identity checks before discussing any client or visit.
- **Produce the 8:30 AM morning handoff summary** from the night's call records.

Assumptions behind the cost estimates

- About 300 to 600 after-hours calls a month across both offices.
- An average of about 3 minutes of AI talk time per call, plus roughly 10 percent more minutes for outbound alert calls to on-call staff. That works out to about 1,000 to 2,000 billable minutes a month.
- Two inbound numbers (one per office line) or one shared number that can tell which office forwarded the call.
- Prices are the published list prices on vendor pages as of early November 2026. Estimates exclude Centratel's own fees, carrier call forwarding charges, and the time to build and test.
- Where a vendor does not publish a price, the estimate is shown as a quote, with any public reference point noted.

Comparison at a glance

Table 1 covers privacy, cost, and the two capabilities that matter most for our workflow: looking up AxisCare during the call and transferring to a person. Table 2 covers the rest.

Table 1. BAA, cost, AxisCare lookups, and transfers

Platform	HIPAA BAA (which plan)	Pricing model	Rough monthly cost (our assumptions)	Calls external APIs mid-call (AxisCare lookups)	Warm transfer to a phone number	Fit for our workflow
Retell AI	Yes, on pay-as-you-go. Self-serve BAA from the dashboard; no Enterprise plan needed (help article).	Per minute, $0.07 to $0.31 (pricing). No contract or minimum.	About $165 to $310 (about $0.14 a minute with PII redaction and guardrails, plus numbers and SMS).	Yes. Custom functions POST to our endpoint and wait for the answer before speaking (docs).	Yes. Warm transfer with a private whisper to the person answering, or cold transfer (docs).	Strong
Vapi	Yes, as a paid HIPAA add-on on any plan, $2,000 a month per organization (HIPAA docs).	Per minute: $0.05 Vapi hosting plus model, voice, and phone costs (pricing).	About $2,100 to $2,300 (usage of about $110 to $260 plus the $2,000 HIPAA add-on).	Yes. Custom tools call our server during the call.	Yes, several warm transfer modes, including a spoken summary (docs).	Capable but costly for our size
Bland AI	Enterprise only. Start and Build plans do not include a BAA (pricing).	Self-serve $0.11 to $0.14 a minute; Enterprise is contracted.	Quote. Self-serve usage would be about $110 to $280, but those plans have no BAA.	Yes. Custom tools and integrations on all plans.	Enterprise only. Warm and live transfers and in-call SMS are Enterprise features.	Only with an Enterprise contract
Synthflow	Yes, under its Enterprise agreement, when the HIPAA setting is turned on (BAA).	Annual enterprise agreement only; no per-minute or self-serve plan (pricing).	Quote. One public pricing tracker lists contracts from about $30,000 a year (source).	Yes. Custom actions call outside APIs during the call.	Yes, call transfer to outside numbers.	Too large a commitment for our size
Goodcall	Yes, on the Scale plan ($299 a month) and Enterprise (FAQ).	Flat monthly price by unique callers; no per-minute charges (pricing).	$299 (Scale includes 2,000 unique callers a month).	Yes. Up to 15 external tools on Scale (an API, an MCP server, or a code block).	Transfers to escalation contacts, retries busy lines, and tries up to three contacts. A whispered warm handoff is not described.	Good for simple use; light on escalation logic
Smith.ai	No. Smith.ai states it is not HIPAA-compliant and cannot handle calls involving PHI (vendor FAQ, quoted by PracticeAIReview).	Per call: Free 25 calls, Pro from $150, Enterprise from $500 for 300 calls (pricing).	About $500 to $1,000.	Limited. Native and Zapier integrations; custom integrations built by their team on Enterprise.	Yes, to its own live receptionists or to our numbers.	Not usable (no BAA)
Hello Patient	Yes. Signs a BAA with every client; SOC 2 Type 2 (FAQ).	Custom flat monthly subscription, scaled by volume.	Quote.	Built by the vendor. Integrates with EHRs through FHIR, HL7, or custom work; AxisCare is not listed.	Routes to staff with context attached.	Built for clinics, not home care

Platform	HIPAA BAA (which plan)	Pricing model	Rough monthly cost (our assumptions)	Calls external APIs mid-call (AxisCare lookups)	Warm transfer to a phone number	Fit for our workflow
Twilio custom build	Yes, with Security or Enterprise Edition, bought through sales (HIPAA accounts). The AI model provider needs its own BAA.	Per minute: Conversation Relay about $0.07 plus voice about $0.0085 (pricing), plus model costs and the edition fee.	Usage of roughly $100 to $220, plus an unpublished edition fee and ongoing developer time.	Yes, anything we code.	Yes, anything we code.	Possible, but the most work
AxisCare Axi Assist	Runs inside AxisCare, which already holds our client data. Whether our current AxisCare BAA covers it needs confirming.	Quote through AxisCare; no public price (product page).	Quote.	Native. Reads the caregiver's visits directly in AxisCare.	Transfers non call-off calls, unverified callers, and requests for a human to the on-call staff member.	Promising for call-offs; scope is narrow
HeyHomeCare	Yes. Signs a BAA with the agency (AxisCare integration page).	Self-serve CRM from $500 a month with 3,000 AI minutes; after-hours-only service is quoted (plans).	Quote. The $500 plan is a reference point, not our price.	Yes, through the AxisCare API. Keeps a copy of visits refreshed every 15 minutes; can write call logs and leads.	Yes. Live transfer to the on-call manager with the facts attached; emergencies always go to a person.	Strong home care fit, to be confirmed
Phoebe	Describes itself as HIPAA-compliant (site); a signed BAA must be requested.	Month-to-month; standard price not published.	Quote.	Yes. Two-way AxisCare sync for shifts.	Escalates to the team with a summary.	Shift coverage tool more than a full answering line

Table 2. Notifications, records, triage, recording notice, and setup

Platform	SMS and email notifications	Call recording and transcripts	Custom triage logic	Florida recording notice	Ease of setup for a non-developer	Notable limitations
Retell AI	SMS after the call ($0.01 a message plus $20 a month). Email or other alerts through post-call webhooks.	Yes. PII redaction, custom retention, and an option to turn recording off.	Yes. Prompt or visual conversation flow with branches for each urgency level.	Yes. A fixed opening message can play before the caller speaks.	Moderate. Templates and a visual builder help, but the AxisCare link and the escalation ladder need a small helper service.	SMS is post-call only for voice agents. Shared servers on pay-as-you-go. We build and maintain the integration.
Vapi	Through tools and webhooks (for example, SMS through a phone provider).	Yes. HIPAA mode changes how logs, recordings, and transcripts are stored.	Yes. Very flexible.	Yes, a fixed first message.	Hard. Built for developers.	HIPAA add-on cost. HIPAA mode limits us to approved model, voice, and transcription providers.
Bland AI	SMS on Enterprise; email through webhooks.	Yes.	Yes. Conversational Pathways for step-by-step flows.	Yes, a fixed first message.	Easy for us on Enterprise, because their engineers build the first agent; a 28-day rollout is typical.	Key features (BAA, warm transfer, SMS) are Enterprise only.
Synthflow	Yes, SMS and webhooks.	Yes.	Yes. No-code flow builder.	Yes, a fixed greeting.	Easy to moderate, with launch support from their team.	Annual contract sized for mid-market and enterprise buyers; no trial.

Platform	SMS and email notifications	Call recording and transcripts	Custom triage logic	Florida recording notice	Ease of setup for a non-developer	Notable limitations
Goodcall	Sends texts (cannot receive replies). Team alerts through workers or Zapier.	Yes, every call recorded and transcribed; unlimited history on Scale.	Basic. “Workers” plus plain-English instructions.	Yes. Configurable greeting; callers are told they are speaking with an AI.	Easiest of the build-it-yourself tools. Changes are described in plain English.	No acknowledgement-based escalation ladder. Unclear whether a whispered handoff to the nurse is possible. Zapier is not a HIPAA tool.
Smith.ai	Yes, SMS and email.	Yes, recording, transcription, and summaries.	Moderate; custom prompting on Enterprise.	Yes.	Easy. Their team builds it on Enterprise.	Not HIPAA-compliant, so it cannot take our calls.
Hello Patient	Voice and SMS.	Yes. Every interaction logged and encrypted.	Yes, built from protocols we approve.	Configured by the vendor.	Easy for us; vendor-led over about six to eight weeks.	Clinic and EHR focus; home care call-offs are not its core use.
Twilio custom build	Twilio SMS and any email service.	Yes, as we build it.	Unlimited, as we build it.	Yes, as we build it.	Hardest. Needs a developer to build and to keep it running.	We own uptime, security, and every model and vendor BAA.
AxisCare Axi Assist	Alerts when it logs a call.	Yes. Every call recorded and summarized in the AxisCare Call Log with playback and a follow-up flag.	Focused on call-offs; other calls are transferred.	To be confirmed whether we can set the greeting wording.	Easiest. No separate system.	Takes the caregiver off the visit and reopens it during the call, which conflicts with our rule that no schedule changes happen without a person confirming. New product (September 2026).
HeyHomeCare	Texts are central (on-call replies by text). Texts name clients by initials only.	Every call, text, reply, and outcome on the record.	Business rules for each scenario; emergencies always to a person; never gives clinical advice.	To be confirmed whether we can set the greeting wording.	Easy. Vendor setup; no code on our side. Needs authorized AxisCare API access.	Built around caregiver calls. Shift outreach and visit write-back must stay switched off for phase 1. After-hours-only price not published.
Phoebe	Text, call, email, and team chat tools.	Calls logged.	Focused on call-outs and filling shifts.	To be confirmed.	Easy. Vendor setup within days.	Not built for family, clinical, or referral triage.

Notes on each platform

The platforms fall into three groups: general voice AI platforms we would configure ourselves, ready-made AI receptionists, and products built for home care. Each note covers what stands out for Nursing Styles.

General voice AI platforms

Retell AI

- **BAA:** Available on the pay-as-you-go plan. Retell's help center says HIPAA does not require Enterprise, and its BAA can be signed online (BAA portal). Retell states its voice and model sub-processors are also covered under BAAs (medical answering page).
- **Cost:** Billed by the second. A typical setup runs about $0.11 a minute; adding phone service ($0.015), PII redaction ($0.01), and safety guardrails ($0.005) brings it to about $0.14. Phone numbers are $2 a month each, SMS is $20 a month plus $0.01 a message, and 20 simultaneous calls are included (pricing). After a transfer, only the phone charge continues.
- **AxisCare:** Custom functions let the agent call our own endpoint mid-call and wait for the reply. A small helper service would hold the AxisCare token, look up the caregiver and next visits, and return only the minimum needed (first name, last initial, date, time).
- **Records and summary:** Post-call webhooks and post-call functions can send each call to the helper, which can write the AxisCare call log and build the 8:30 AM summary (webhooks).
- **Watch for:** We build and own the helper service and the escalation ladder logic (placing outbound alert calls and tracking acknowledgements). Enterprise adds role-based access, SSO, and named support if we later want them.

Vapi

- **BAA:** HIPAA mode is an organization-wide paid add-on. Turning it on in the dashboard triggers a BAA by email and limits the account to HIPAA-compatible providers (HIPAA docs). The add-on is listed at $2,000 a month per organization (pricing and packages).
- **Cost:** Usage is low (about $0.11 to $0.13 a minute all in), but the HIPAA add-on alone is roughly ten times our expected usage.
- **Strengths:** Very flexible tools, warm transfer with a spoken summary, and strong testing tools.
- **Watch for:** Developer-oriented; harder for office staff to adjust. HIPAA mode and zero data retention cannot both be on.

Bland AI

- **BAA:** Only on Enterprise, along with SSO and data residency (pricing).
- **Cost:** Self-serve rates are $0.14 a minute (Start) and $0.12 a minute (Build, $299 a month) (billing docs), but those plans have no BAA, warm transfer, or SMS. Enterprise is priced by contract.
- **Watch for:** A strong platform, but we would be buying an enterprise relationship for a small after-hours line.

Synthflow

- **BAA:** Signed at contract time for customers who use the HIPAA setting (BAA template).

- **Cost:** Annual enterprise agreements only, with no free plan, trial, or per-minute option (pricing).
- **Watch for:** No-code tools are friendly, but the buying model is sized for much larger call centers.

Twilio custom build

- **BAA:** Twilio signs a BAA only for HIPAA accounts on Security or Enterprise Edition, purchased through sales. Conversation Relay and Programmable Voice are on Twilio's HIPAA-eligible list (eligible services). The AI model provider (for example, a cloud provider's hosted model) needs its own BAA.
- **Cost:** Conversation Relay about $0.07 a minute plus inbound voice about $0.0085 a minute and $1.15 a month per local number (voice pricing), plus model costs and the edition fee.
- **Watch for:** Complete control, but we would be running our own phone software, around the clock, for a clinical-adjacent line. Better suited to a later phase, if ever.

Ready-made AI receptionists

Goodcall

- **BAA:** Available on Scale ($299 a month) and Enterprise; Goodcall has a standard BAA and will review our own form (FAQ).
- **Cost:** Flat price per unique caller, not per minute. Scale covers 2,000 unique callers a month, well above our volume (pricing).
- **Strengths:** The simplest setup of the configurable tools. Changes are described in plain English, callers are told they are speaking with an AI, every call is recorded and transcribed, and external API tools can reach a helper service for AxisCare lookups.
- **Watch for:** Built for small businesses taking bookings. It can transfer to up to three contacts in turn, but our timed, acknowledgement-based escalation ladder and outbound alert calls would need outside tooling. Its texts are send-only. Zapier, its main connector, does not fit HIPAA workflows.

Smith.ai

- **BAA:** Smith.ai's own FAQ states it is not HIPAA-compliant and cannot handle calls involving PHI, as quoted by PracticeAIReview. Some third-party articles describe a HIPAA tier; nothing on Smith.ai's pages supports that.
- **Cost:** Per call, from $500 a month for 300 calls on Enterprise (pricing).
- **Why it is attractive anyway:** AI first, with human receptionists behind it at any hour, which is close to the model we want. Without a BAA, though, it cannot take our calls. Centratel already fills the live backup role.

Hello Patient

- **BAA:** Signs a BAA with every client and is SOC 2 Type 2 certified (FAQ).
- **Fit:** Strong clinical guardrails (it never gives medical advice and escalates clinical calls), but it is built around clinic scheduling, refills, and EHRs such as athenaOne. Home care call-offs and AxisCare are not part of its standard offering.
- **Cost and timing:** Custom monthly pricing; most clients go live in six to eight weeks.

Products built for home care

AxisCare Axi Assist

- **What it is:** AxisCare's own AI receptionist, released September 28, 2026 (announcement). It answers inbound calls at any hour, identifies the caregiver, reads back their visits in plain language, and records the call-off. Every call is recorded and summarized in the AxisCare Call Log with a follow-up flag (product page).
- **Strengths:** No separate system, no integration to build, and our data already lives in AxisCare. It follows Spanish-speaking callers in Spanish. It also chases missed clock-ins automatically.
- **Watch for:** As described, it takes the caregiver off the visit and reopens it during the call. Our workflow says no schedule changes without a person confirming, so we would need that step to be optional. Anything that is not a call-off is transferred to the on-call staff member, so it does not replace our four-level triage, the 911 script, or the Centratel transfer on its own. Pricing is not published.

HeyHomeCare

- **What it is:** An AI voice and text line for home care agencies, with AxisCare as its reference integration (AxisCare after-hours page).
- **AxisCare:** Connects through the AxisCare API with a token our admin creates. It reads caregivers, clients, responsible parties (authorized family contacts), visits, and clock-ins, refreshed every 15 minutes. It can write a call log, a lead, and a covered visit, each behind a switch we control.
- **Privacy:** Signs a BAA with the agency, encrypts the AxisCare token, redacts PHI from logs, and names clients by initials only in texts.
- **Safety:** Emergencies always go to a person, it never gives clinical advice, and a caller who asks for a person is transferred live to on-call.
- **Watch for:** Its core is caregiver calls (call-offs, missed clock-ins, replacement outreach) and new-client inquiries. We would need to confirm it can run our full triage for clients, families, and referral sources, transfer to Centratel, and follow our escalation ladder. Shift outreach and visit write-back would stay off in phase 1. The after-hours-only service is quoted by sales and needs authorized AxisCare vendor access.

Phoebe

- **What it is:** An AI scheduling assistant that answers caregiver call-outs, logs them, and texts or calls eligible caregivers to fill the shift. It syncs with AxisCare (site).
- **Watch for:** Built to fill shifts rather than to answer every after-hours call, so it would not cover family, clinical, or referral calls. Pricing is not published. It may be worth revisiting in phase 2, if we want help covering open shifts.

Considered and set aside

- **Air AI:** No longer sold. The product has been discontinued, so there is nothing to sign or buy (status summary).
- **Serve:** An AI receptionist for home care that lists AxisCare as a supported system, but it is currently taking agencies by waitlist only (site).

Recommendation

Top pick: Retell AI

Retell meets every requirement in our workflow at the lowest cost, and it does not force us into an enterprise contract to get a BAA. It can look up AxisCare during the call through a small helper service, warm-transfer to the on-call nurse or to Centratel with a private whisper, play our greeting and recording notice before the caller says anything, and send every finished call to our helper for the AxisCare call log and the morning summary. At our volume it should cost about $165 to $310 a month, billed by the second with no minimum, so a quiet month costs less.

The trade-off is effort. Khaim would build and maintain the helper service and the escalation ladder, and office staff would rely on him for larger changes. That fits the plan already in the workflow document, and it keeps every triage rule in our hands.

Runner-up: HeyHomeCare

If we would rather buy a finished home care product than build one, HeyHomeCare is the strongest option. It already connects to AxisCare, signs a BAA, keeps emergencies and clinical questions with people, and needs no code on our side. Before choosing it, we would need a quote for after-hours-only service and confirmation that it can run our full four-level triage for every caller type, transfer to Centratel, and leave schedules untouched in phase 1.

Also worth a demo: AxisCare Axi Assist

Because it lives inside the system we already use, it is worth asking AxisCare for a demo and a price. Its call-off handling and call log are close to what we want. Its automatic removal of the caregiver from the visit, and its narrow scope beyond call-offs, mean it would most likely complement the main agent rather than replace it.

Suggested next steps

1. Share this comparison with Shaun and agree on the top pick.
2. Ask our AxisCare account manager about API access for our site and whether Axi Assist can run without changing visits automatically.
3. Request the Retell BAA and review it with whoever handles our HIPAA agreements before any real call data is used.
4. Build a test agent on Retell using made-up callers only, and walk through each urgency level with the office team.
5. In parallel, request a quote and demo from HeyHomeCare as the fallback.

Open Questions

- **Retell BAA scope:** Does the self-serve BAA cover call recordings, transcripts, SMS, and the phone numbers Retell provides, and which model and voice providers are covered under its downstream BAAs?

- **Helper service:** Where will the AxisCare helper run, and under whose BAA? Options include a cloud provider that signs a BAA, or AxisCare Amplifier (powered by Workato) if AxisCare confirms it can respond to live requests during a call and is covered by a BAA.
- **AxisCare API access:** Is API access already included for our site, can tokens be limited to read-only lookups plus call log writes, and are call log writes allowed for our account?
- **Our existing AxisCare agreement:** Does our current BAA with AxisCare cover Axi Assist, and is Axi Assist priced separately?
- **Axi Assist behavior:** Can the automatic removal of the caregiver from the visit be turned off, can we set the greeting and recording notice wording, and can it transfer to Centratel?
- **HeyHomeCare scope and price:** What does after-hours-only service cost for an agency our size, and can it handle family, clinical, and referral calls with our four urgency levels?
- **Call volume and length:** Our estimates assume 300 to 600 calls a month at about 3 minutes each. A month of Centratel call reports would confirm the real numbers.
- **Recording on transferred calls:** When a call is transferred to Centratel or the on-call nurse, will the platform keep recording the transferred part, and does that need a separate notice to staff or Centratel operators?
- **Office phone forwarding:** Can our current phone system or carrier forward both lines on a schedule (5:00 PM on, 9:00 AM off), with forward on no answer going to Centratel?
- **Data retention:** How long should recordings and transcripts be kept under our retention policy, and does each platform let us set automatic deletion to match?
- **No training on our data:** Each vendor and its model providers need to confirm in writing that our call data will not be used to train their models.

References

Source	Link
Retell AI pricing	https://www.retellai.com/pricing
Retell AI: HIPAA without Enterprise (help center)	https://retell-ai-help-center.help.usepylon.com/articles/4276520278-do-i-need-to-purchase-the-enterprise-plan-to-have-hipaa-compliance-with-retell
Retell AI custom functions	https://docs.retellai.com/build/single-multi-prompt/custom-function
Retell AI call transfer	https://docs.retellai.com/build/single-multi-prompt/transfer-call
Vapi HIPAA compliance	https://docs.vapi.ai/security-and-privacy/hipaa
Vapi pricing	https://vapi.ai/pricing
Bland AI pricing	https://www.bland.ai/pricing
Synthflow pricing	https://synthflow.ai/pricing
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Goodcall FAQ (pricing and HIPAA)	https://www.goodcall.com/faq
Smith.ai AI Receptionist pricing	https://smith.ai/pricing/ai-receptionist
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